The Filipino Drama

I. Articles about Filipino Drama in the 21st Century

Evolution of Philippine Theater

by Solaire Resort

Pre-colonial Time

During the pre-historic times, theater in the Philippines was in the form of indigenous rituals, verbal jousts or games, or songs and dances to praise gods. According to early chronicles, pre-historic dramas consisted of three elements – myth, mimesis, and spectacle.

These mimetic performances mostly dramatized primitive rituals and epic poetry about deities and mythical legends, where the spirit of the deities would seemingly possess a catalonan (priest) or babaylan (priestess).

During this entranced state, the priest or priestess would consume the sacrificial offering, which could be in the form of a pig, chicken, rice, wine, or nuts.

"…seemed to shoot flames from her eyes; her hair stood on end, a fearful sight to those beholding, and she uttered words of arrogance and superiority." – Juan de Plasencia, 1590

Spanish Regime

When the Spaniards reached our shores, they used dramas such as zarzuelas as a pedagogical tool to influence the pagan tribes and teach them about Christianity and religion.

Another important form of theater popularized during the Spanish colonization is the comedia, also known as moro-moro, linambay, or arakyo. It's a play in verse that portrays the lives, loves, and wars of moors and Christians.

Moro-Moro is a secular comedy that dramatizes the war between Christians and Muslims through the forbidden love between the prince and the princess. The comedy is resolved with the non-Christian being converted to Christianity, or through his or her death, immediately followed by his or her resurrection.

Comedias were normally performed in the pueblos or village centers to attract more people to the foundation of its regime. The comedia can last anywhere from 3 to 15 hours through a series of performances. The first Filipino comedia was performed in Latin and Spanish by Fr. Vicente Puche in Cebu in 1598.

On the other hand, a zarzuela is a form of musical theater that combines spoken word and song that celebrates various Catholic liturgical feasts. Jugar Con Fuego by Francisco Asenjo Barbieri was the first zarzuela introduced in the country in late 1878 or early 1879.

By August 17, 1893, Teatro Zorilla, the home of zarzuela, was inaugurated.

Throughout the 333 years of the Spanish regime, the Philippines was widely influenced by their culture, tradition, and religion. Today, zarzuelas and comedias are still being performed, albeit with other cultural influences and contemporary touches.

American Colonization

When American colonial rule was established, the United States introduced the American way of life through education, media, and language. Their influence on Philippine theatre is most apparent through the bodabil (vaudeville) and the plays and dramas staged or translated into English.

In 1898, the first bodabil was produced by the Manila Dramatic Guild for the sole purpose of entertaining American soldiers and other Americans residing in Manila. It was also the first theatrical performance since the revolution.

The bodabil is not a straight-up play. The theatrical performance

is, in fact, a mix of songs, dances, comedy skits, and even magical performances. Local audiences bought-in and productions soon found themselves becoming entertainment spectacles that can be transported from one town to the next. Not long after, the bodabil was interjected into comedias and zarzuelas, as intermission numbers known as jamborees.

In the 1930s, the country was introduced to Broadway theatre or stage plays through the westernized education that was provided in most private schools for privileged children. Shakespearean tragedies and comedies, as well as western classics, were performed in the original English or English adaptation.

The Japanese Occupation

By the 1940s, when the Japanese took over the Philippines from the Americans, movie actors and actresses could no longer appear in films, as the Japanese confiscated all film equipment. However, the comedia, zarzuela, and bodabil remained in the country as forms of entertainment and expression.

Eventually, the bodabil evolved to become stage shows or variety shows with a short melodrama at the end to accommodate the actors and actresses who moved their craft to bodabil and theatre. Venues such as the Manila Grand Opera House and the Savoy Theatre became homes of bodabil.

After the war, movies returned to popularity, and the bodabil era slowly lost its luster. Stage shows became small, cheap performances held in open-air stages in the provinces. Sadly, the bodabil deteriorated decades later to become burlesque and strip shows held in cheap theatres around American military bases.

Philippine Theatre as We Know It Today

After the Japanese occupation, the Philippine theatre has evolved to become an amalgamation of the various influences such that of the zarzuela, comedia, bodabil, and western classics. Theatre was largely performed in English during the time, as it became a large part of classroom education. Meanwhile, zarzuelas such as “Ang Kiri,” “Dalagang Bukid,” and “Paglipis ng Dilim” became well-known beyond their regions.

By the 1950s, theatre had moved out of classrooms and the concept of paying for a ticket to see a theatrical performance emerged. This “legitimate” theatre was held in closed theaters – these became events in themselves, not just mere parts of a celebration or religious ritual.

During this time, playwrights such as Severino Montano, Wilfrido Ma. Guerrero, and Alberto S. Florentino honed their crafts and contributed to the development of performing arts in the Philippines.

Through the years, Philippine theatre groups have staged numerous plays in both English and Filipino, be it written by a Western or local playwright. Spanish culture and traditions largely influence performing arts in the Philippines, but the contemporary style is borrowed from the Americans.

Reflection: A Look Back at Philippine Theater in 2015

By Jared Echevarria

Manila, Philippines--In a time when the Philippines is proving its economic and cultural prowess on the global stage, theater seems to be a good medium to mirror not only the varied tastes of its society but also to develop the level of maturity of art appreciation among its people.

Theater is not a new thing in the Philippines; in fact, it has been part of its great "cultural menu" that nourished the nation and carved her becoming. It is, therefore, a part of every Filipino's life every once in a while.

With the growing awareness of theater in the country, brought about by the successes of Filipino thespians here and abroad, the

nation is clamoring for more and more productions, where theater companies exhibit their homegrown talents and creative minds. When it comes to producing theater, Filipinos do not favor quantity over quality; that's why some shows only play for a week or a weekend.

The Philippines, especially Manila, is not considered Asia's theater capital yet, but we can easily say that we're gearing towards that global recognition. 2015 was a great year because theatrical productions were brought closer to a lot more people--the antithesis that theater only caters to a niche audience. The productions in the past year reached varied audiences with themes that touched various sensitive topics and controversies; these productions proved to be not only a form of entertainment but also a receptacle of personal reflections for some audiences saw things in a way that the others did not.

"Abundance" best describes the theater scene in 2015, in which varied selections of productions have been presented and even restaged because of popular demand. Below are a just a handful of previous productions that proved the point that theater in the Philippines now caters to all generations, varied sectors of the society and interests.

Third Person Collective's "Peratedes," a stage adaption of Federico Lorca's "La Casa de Bernarda Alba," directed by Harry David, was a reflection of a Filipino family with all its secrets, sensitivities, and sacrednesses. This production did not come short and even went further in exposing the good and the bad in a Filipino household. In fact, it didn't end there: it provided a solution that was left for the audiences to fathom.

Egg Theater Company's "Maniacal," a stage adaptation of Moliere's "Les Femmes Savantes," directed by George de Jesus, was a satire of the theater industry in Manila. It was a fascinating material that explored the industry through relatable references and powerful dialogues.

The Necessary Theater by Actor's Actors Inc.'s "The Normal Heart," directed by Bart Guingona, tackled a sensitive topic with the guidance of a great and pulsating script, which literally informed the audiences of an ongoing war against HIV and AIDS epidemic.

Red Turnip Theater's small but sleek production of "This is Our Youth," directed by Topper Fabregas, was a fitting tribute to a decade of social uneasiness and confusion. The lines in the play were all powerful but not vulgar.

The international touring production of "Singin' in The Rain," inspired by the 1952 movie that starred Gene Kelly, was a hit not only among older audiences but also the millennials. The production brought back the most unforgettable songs from the movie, which were likewise nostalgic and praiseworthy.

Atlantis Theatrical Entertainment Group's (ATEG) "The Bridges of Madison County," directed by Bobby Garcia, was the first international production of the Tony Award-winning musical. Though not considered a classic yet, the songs and its immortal story cemented rave reviews for the production. The direction and stage design were subtle, yet effective.

Triumphant People's Evangelistic Society's (Trumpets) "A Horse and His Boy," a stage adaptation of the well-loved C.S. Lewis classic, brought back the audiences to the world of Narnia with all its mysteries and splendors. The children in the audience surely loved the show; the adults in the audience, on the other hand, appreciated every single line in its script and its hauntingly beautiful musical score.

The international touring production of "Cookin' Nanta," a Korean non-verbal musical, was a treat to the audiences. The upbeat and funny antics of the actors onstage drummed up their way through as one of the most entertaining productions in 2015.

Repertory Philippines' "The Secret Garden" brought to life a classic story of friendship and family, which taught invaluable

life lessons still applicable in the present day.
The international touring production of "La Soiree," a cabaret-variety show, also had its share of amusing the audiences and making others burst into laughter. It was a show that ensured that no one in the theatre would be left unsatisfied.
2015 was a kind year to everyone involved in the Philippine theater scene--both its practitioners and the audiences. It was a year full of entertainment that made theatergoers realize that this industry has no signs of slowing down in the years to come.

Theatre in the 21st century
By The Freeman

CEBU, Philippines — Once, in a keynote speech addressed to the Association of Theatre in Higher Education, in 1992, performance studies scholar Richard Schechner (in)famously declared: “Theatre as we have known and practiced it – the staging of written dramas – will be the string quartet of the 21st century.”
We are now almost three decades removed from this provocation. What, if anything, has changed about the state of theatre in the 21st century? Is theatre dead, as Schechner predicted, or is it still very much alive and breathing? In the spirit of retired “Late Show” host David Letterman’s famous “Top Ten” lists, here 10 reasons why theatre is still important today:

#10 Human Beings
The performance of theatre is a universal cultural phenomenon that exists in every society around the world. Human beings are the only animal species that creates theatre. Understanding theatre helps us understand what it means to be human.

#9 Self-Expression
Theatre teaches us how to express ourselves more effectively. It develops our ability to communicate our thoughts and feelings to others, improving our relationships and improving the world around us.

#8 Self-Knowledge
Theatre teaches us about ourselves. It helps us understand how our minds and the minds of others work. It helps us to see how the environments in which we live affect who we are and who we will become.

#7 History
Theatre is a great way to lean about history. Rather than learning history from reading it in a dusty textbook, theatre makes history come alive right before our eyes. Theatre makes learning about history fun.

#6 The Human Body
Theatre reminds us that, even in this ever-changing digital age, there is a human body at the center of every digital transaction. Accounting for the body in the design of the future will help us make technology that works for us rather than us working for technology.

#5 Globalization
Theatre helps us understand people from cultures other than our own. We can learn a lot about people from cultures all around the world by studying their performance traditions. In doing so, we can learn to be less ethnocentric, and more accepting of others.

#4 Self-Empowerment
Performance permeates every aspect of our everyday lives. Power relationships are constructed through performances. Understanding how performances unfold around us can help us to recognize and take control of the power dynamics that affect us.

#3 Social Change
Theatre is a cultural space where society examines itself in a mirror. Theatre has long been looked at as a laboratory in which we can study the problems that confront society, and attempt to solve those problems.

#2 Education
Theatre is a great way to learn. Going to the theatre teaches us about people, places, and ideas to which we would not otherwise be exposed. Learning in a theatrical setting makes learning fun.

#1 Creativity
Theatre helps us to develop our creativity. As our education system increasingly puts an emphasis on science, technology, engineering, and math, we cannot forget the importance of art. Theater puts the "STE(A)M" back in "STEM!" (www.tcgcircle.org) - Kevin Brown

Lack of financing, audience hounds Philippine theater
By Brylle B. Tabora

Modern theater has come a long way in the Philippines since it made its arrival during the American Occupation. But challenges remain, especially the lack of financial wherewithal and support from the state. Then there's the seeming paucity in audience.

The literary forum "Ang Teatro sa Pilipinas sa Bagong Milenyo," organized by the University of Santo Tomas Center for Creative Writing and Literary Studies, recently featured theater artists Rody Vera, Nicolas B. Pichay, Liza Magtoto and Sir Anril Tiatco discussing the poor state of Philippine theater.

"There is a financial catastrophe that we feel in theater because we don't have any funding, we don't have support from the Government unless we apply for a grant," said Magtoto, whose recent works included the hit musical "Rak of Aegis." She said professior theater was in its death throes ("naghihikahos").

She noted that many companies were having a hard time inviting audience to watch their shows because of the high ticket prices. "Audience building is really difficult," she said. "The good thing about this, however, is that many theater companies were conceived. But many theater companies are having a problem with marketing. Unless it was free of charge, it was difficult to bring in audience."

'Urgency'
Tiatco, who teaches at the Department of Speech Communication and Theater Arts in University of the Philippines Diliman, said that contemporary theater in the Philippines, or at least in Manila, is rooted in social criticism. Citing critic Doreen G. Fernandez, he noted that with thematic concerns of the Filipino playwrights, directors and actors, "the vitality of theater is in its urgency."

"[Filipino playwrights] do not need to hear the strengths in writing techniques in order to want to write a play in like

manner; instead, their themes invade their craft and they reach for techniques," he said. "By urgency, Fernandez said theater in the Philippines used to represent social concerns of the time and therefore provide a commentary on the state of things at that time."

Tiatco stressed that contemporary artists behind the staging of current productions "worked on the same tradition of social activism which might be viewed as a call for resisting certain social and cultural threats while the real are imagined."

In the same vein, Vera noted the tradition of well-known Filipino playwrights such as Reuel Aguila, Rene Villanueva, Al Santos, Malou Jacob who wrote because of the "urgency of the time".

"It was important for them to say what they wanted to say more than how they could say it," said Vera, who was inducted this year in the Palanca Awards Hall of Fame. "It was clear to them what they wanted to send across their audience."

Musicals

Writer-lawyer Pichay, who wrote "Maxie The Musicale," noted the rise of musical theater.

"We have a musical culture," Pichay said. "We are a karaoke nation. We have a theatrical tradition with moro-moro, zarzuela and vaudeville."

Pichay noted that the Filipino people's penchant for musicals came around in the 1980s when the whole world began to notice then 17-year-old Lea Salonga, who played Kim in the musical "Miss Saigon."

Meanwhile, Magtoto, who wrote the musical "Care Divas," noted the rise of theater-goers in the country because of musical productions, but she said that the theater did not always have to show musicals.

Gay Sensibility

The gay sensibility in musicals has long been a heated discussion in queer theories.

But what is gay sensibility?

According to Pichay, it is the way in which the world is viewed through the eyes of a gay person. However, he said that this was hard to signify because one cannot actually define this.

Pichay was referring to an article written by Anthony Tommasini for the New York Times in which the latter argued that the notion of "gay sensibility" associated to musicals came from the fact that the earlier productions were written mostly be gay people.

"Would it help to think that that musicals have actuality that is mostly associated with the gay culture?" asked Pichay. "Masaya lang talaga ang kumanta and sumayaw, but it doesn't necessarily mean that the person who is enjoying a musical is gay."

Performance and Literature

Vera, who was one of the co-founders of the 10-year-running Virgin Labfest, said that the festival sought to reconcile drama and literature, performativity and literary quality.

In the '90s, playwright Rene Villanueva set up the group called Telon where Pichay, Elmer Gatchalian, Jun Lana, Tim Dacanay,

Luna Sicat-Cleto were members. The group was largely built because of their belief that "the true test of a play was to be in production."

Then, the late Charley de la Paz founded the Playwrights' Development Program of the Philippine Educational Theater Association (Peta), which was later joined with Telon to form what would be called the Writers' Bloc, which Vera now heads. Vera said that it was important for them that the drama they write would be eventually translated on stage.

"In film writing, the work must be set to production before we could say that this was what had become of it. Sometimes what the actors say help to contribute in enriching the material. Not only the light and 'literariness' of the words, but also its stageability. This is the vision of Virgin Labfest."

Meanwhile, Pichay said that the theater offered more engagement than did TV shows or films. He stressed that in the age of social media, TV had created a big divide among the people because it did not build a community, only consumerism. "In the Greek times, the theater really was a community," he said. "When you build a community, you build a theater. The theater should entertain and educate. It should address a particular audience and make people introspective and let them know their place in society. That is what we want the theater to be."

II. Notable Theater Groups in the Philippines

A. Tanghalang Pilipino

Founded in 1987 as the resident theater company of the Cultural Center of the Philippines (CCP), Tanghalang Pilipino aims to promote Philippine theater that is rooted in centuries-old Filipino culture and history while being responsive to evolving contemporary society.

Tanghalang Pilipino maintains the highest standards in artistic discipline, technical skill, and professional conduct. With the goal of offering diverse content to cater to a broad spectrum of theater-goers, they balance their programming of the season to include Filipino works (both classic and contemporary), translations and adaptations of theater materials from Asia and other parts of the globe, as well as children's theater.

They also conduct Kamalayang Pilipino Workshop in the Arts (KAPWA), a theater workshop framework that focuses on identifying the roots of a community and using theater as a tool for self-discovery and empowerment.

Tanghalang Pilipino is unique among other theater groups in the country because they maintain a core of actors whose full-time training in acting is subsidized by the company. Known as the Tanghalang Pilipino Actors Company, these actors are tapped for the company's season repertoire and special performances. The actors who have graduated from the Actors Company now compromise the most sought-after stable of talents in television, cinema, and commercial advertising.
In addition to honing skills for on-stage performance, they also commit to the development of an active audience for Filipino theater through using the native language as their primary medium for their productions and by bringing their performances to venues outside CCP- to various parts of the country and overseas,

especially locations with large Filipino communities.

Notable productions of the company are *Prinsipe Munti,* an adaptation of Antoine de Saint-Exupéry's *Le Petit Prince, Sandosenang Sapatos, Melanie, Ang Paguusig (The Crucible)* by Arthur Miller's, *Nang Dalawin ng Pag-ibig si Juan Tamad,* and *Walang Aray* - a contemporized comic version of Severino Reyes' *Walang Sugat.*

B. Philippine Educational Theater Association

Cecile Guidote-Alvarez founded the Philippine Educational Theater Association (PETA) on April 7, 1967, with the vision of a Philippine Theater engaged in the development of people and society.

In 1971, PETA became the UNESCO-ITI (International Theater Institute) Center in the Philippines, and in the same year it organized the first Third World Theater Festival, held in the 400th year of the foundation of the City of Manila.

When its founder was forced to go on political exile because of Martial Law in 1972, PETA's new breed of artist-teacher-leaders continued to steer the company towards a People's Theater committed to social change. The social conditions and political climate during the Martial Law sharpened the people-based theater aesthetics of PETA. It inspired the company to use the power of theater as a means of producing plays for empowerment and development, especially of the most disadvantaged sectors of society/those in the margins.

PETA began by asserting the then radical view of creating and performing plays in Filipino. Most of PETA's plays were staged at the historic Dulaang Rajah Sulayman, an open-air theater designed by National Artist Leandro V. Locsin. By the 90's, it boasted of a solid record of some 300 plays written, translated, adapted, published and performed, which shaped the company's theater history, enriching it through theater forms and techniques that expressed local, national and universal themes. Among PETA's earlier plays have been: *Bayaning Huwad, Larawan, May-i, May-i, Hanggang Dito na Lamang at Maraming Salamat, Juan Tamban, Pilipinas Circa 1907, Ang Buhay ni Galileo, Macbeth, Canuplin, Macliing, Minsa'y Isang Gamu-Gamo, Ang Paglalakbay ni Radya Mangandiri, 1896.*

In 2005 PETA fulfilled one of long-term goals when it moved to a permanent home, The PETA Theater Center. A landmark in Philippine Arts and Culture, the center in itself is a testament to the creativity, ingenuity, resilience of PETA. The center now serves as a physical base for the entire gamut of PETA undertakings, from professional theater repertory performances, year-round workshops and its community and outreach programs.

Settled in its new home, PETA continued to mount out-of-the-box, cutting-edge productions that mainstreamed relevant issues that engaged its urban audiences. PETA's modern repertoire ranged from fresh adaptations of world classics like *Haring Lear, Arbol de Fuego* (Anton Chekhov's The Cherry Orchard), to staging iconic children's theater productions like *Mga Kuwento ni Lola Basyang*, and *Batang Rizal*. Most recently, the company

has also explored the use of modern pop music to maintain the connection with its evolving audience. Its contemporary musicals include *Skin Deep, William, Care Divas,* and its phenomenal musical hit *Rak of Aegis*.

Relentless in seeking out new audiences, it vigorously partnered with schools, parishes and communities all over the country to ensure that it is able to share its rich educational performances to as many Filipinos as possible. The company embarked on many exhilarating tours. Its mobile plays included *Tumawag kay Libby Manaoag, Si Juan Tamad and Diyablo at ang Limang Milyong Boto, Hans Christian Andersen Must Be a Filipino, Noli at Fili Dekada dos Mil, Rated:PG, ASL...Please!* and *Padayon*.

Through its inspired leadership and the contribution of its dedicated members and staff, PETA mastered its triple bottom lines of artistic excellence, relevance and viability while remaining true to its vision of using theater as a tool for education, social change and development.

C. Repertory Philippines Foundation, Inc.

Founded in 1967 by a group of actors on the initiative of the late Zeneida A. Amador who was its President and Artistic Director until her death in 2005, Repertory Philippines Foundation, Inc., also known as "REP", has often been called "the most professional English-speaking theater company in the country".

It is the only theater company that produces western plays – both modern and the classics – non-stop throughout the year except for the summer months when attention turns to Performing Arts workshops and their corresponding showcase productions. To this date, it has staged 450 productions – each running from 12 to 60 performances. The roster of its productions include such titles as *Les Miserables, The King and I, Passion, Evita, Annie, My Fair Lady, La Cage Aux Folles, Ain't Misbehavin, Kiss of the Spider Woman, South Pacific, Jesus Christ Superstar, Joseph and the Amazing Tecnicolor Dreamcoat, Carousel, Pirates of Penzance A Christmas Carol, A Little Night Music, Oliver, The Secret Garden* and a host of others. One of its recent musical productions, *Les Miserables,* was called the best musical and perhaps the best musical ever in this country.

At present REP has one regular season of three plays. Classics, comedies, dramas and sometimes a smallscale musical are a regular part of each season. The rest of the year is taken up by a musical for young audiences, and time permitting, a big Broadway musical production. Recently REP has taken to adapting at least one play and putting it in a Philippine setting although all the plays are performed in English. Some of the famous western plays that REP has done include *Amadeus, Les Liasons Dangereuses, The Mousetrap, Agnes of God, M. Butterfly, Woman in Black, Our Town, The Importance of Being Earnest, Run For Your Wife, Two and Two Make Sex, The Lion in Winter, Arsenic and Old Lace, Cactus Flower* and many, many others.

The children are not forgotten. The Rep Theater for

Young Audiences, now on its 25th year, stages professional productions of classic children's musicals on weekends and during the week for schools. Ms. Joy Virata is its Founder and Artistic Director.

REP also opens summer Performing Arts workshops attended by more than 200 children and adults each summer.

But Repertory Philippines is not just a production outfit. It has also been the best-known training ground for actors having produced the likes of Lea Salonga who first appeared with REP when she was six years old and then played the lead in *Annie* when she was eight. She went on to play the lead in Cameron Mackintosh's *Miss Saigon*, winning awards in both London and New York for her performance and since then has been an international performer. Monique Wilson, another "Rep tot", also starred in the same production and is at present based in Manila and travels the world over where she continues to pursue her career. The late Junix Inocian, Jonjon Briones, Red Concepcion, Cocoy Laurel, Maya Barredo, and Gia Macuja are just a few of others numbering about 40 who have appeared and are still appearing in international productions. REP continues to be the source of acting talent both in the Philippines and abroad.

To carry out its vision, REP maintains a full-time support staff of 10. Its present address is at Ecoville Executive Townhomes in Makati City. It began using a 200-seat theater on the 12th floor of the Insular Life Building on Ayala Avenue, moved to a 500-seat theater at the Shangri-la Plaza Mall which it named the William J. Shaw Theater, and then, when that theater was demolished, moved to the Carlos P. Romulo 400-seat theater in the RCBC Plaza. At present it rents the Onstage Theater in Greenbelt I in the Ayala Center.

REP is now led by Mindy Barredo Perez-Rubio.

Ms. Zeneida Amador, in an article she wrote profiling her company said: "Because REP is a non-stock, not-for profit foundation, it has never stinted in giving each production the best it has been able to. The money it makes from box-office sales and sponsorship grants have been ploughed back to production budgets to give each presentation the taste, the look and the sophistication that cosmopolites have become used to. Its sense of pride about one of the country's products renders it at all times unable to settle for mediocrity and to daily reach for excellence."

Further, by the regularity of its productions, REP is continuing its furtherance of the aims of art. That is to make people more sensitive, more aware, more ethical in their dealing with others, more compassionate and more just.

D. Gantimpala Theater Foundation

Gantimpala Theater's history began at the Cultural Center of the Philippines (CCP) in 1978. Founding President and Artistic Director, Tony S. Espejo introduced the concept of Black Box Theater in the country be establishing Bulwagang Gantimpala - a bold move that paved the way for the Filipino literary writers'

foray into the theater scene. Gantimpala Theater gave the young the opportunity to exercise their artistry in the different fields of theater discipline. It gave life to the winning plays of the prestigious Palanca Literary Contest and the defunct CCP Gantimpala Playwriting Contest.

Performances were held at the quaint, informal, wooden-benched and balconied theater venue that could seat an audience of 300 (now known as CCP's Tanghalang Huseng Batute) delighted the public, were the talk of the town, earned considerably at the box-office, received critical acclaim, and became the benchmark of world-class Filipino theater.

In 1986, Gantimpala Theater became an independent theater company, made into a foundation and shifted its artistic gears by giving life to plays based on the Philippines' Cultural and Literary Heritage. Its inception of study aides by staging the korido of *Ibong Adarna*, the beauty of spoken Tagalog poetry in *Florante at Laura, Noli Me Tangere* and *El Filibusterismo,* novels of National Hero Dr. Jose Rizal became a major contribution of Gantimpala Theater in the learning and teaching process for students and teachers alike. Other contemporary works of National Artists for Literature, as well as adaptations of children's classic stories into entertaining musical plays were staged to the delight of thousands of audience every season.

Gantimpala Theater is a self-sustaining, independent theater company, with an all year-round season. It promotes goodwill and brings theater arts closer to the people as it goes to nearby provinces and far-flung localities with touring plays. It informs, entertains, and educates more than half-a-million people annually. Indeed, Gantimpala Theater is The Pioneer in Edutainment.

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